José de Lima Massano

(mah-SAH-noo)

Minister of State for Economic Coordination
Republic of Angola

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **June 2023**

José de Lima Massano is a reformist central banker whose role as super-minister of Angola's economy entails navigating financial headwinds, vested political interests, and public frustrations to drive the country's economic transformation.

- **A Technocrat's Values**
  Massano presents himself as a technocrat—someone who applies international standards to a difficult environment and accepts the criticism that comes with it. In an interview, he said civil servants try to do their work "to the best of our abilities" and put "the public interest first."

- **A Politician's Instincts**
  Massano has survived Angola's shifting political landscape, serving under both José Eduardo dos Santos and João Lourenço. He resigned from the National Bank of Angola (BNA) during an unfolding crisis in January 2015, allowing him to return in 2017 with his reputation mainly intact.

Massano's own public statements strongly suggest that he is driven by a legacy ambition: to be associated with Angola's transition away from oil dependence toward a more diversified economy. He seems to prize international validation, as much as domestic acclaim.

WHY THEY MATTER

Massano is seeking to elevate food security from a social policy goal to an economic strategy, positioning agriculture as a critical pillar in his effort to diversify the economy.

- **Betting on Agriculture**
  Massano sees higher domestic production as the route to ease inflation, strengthen the kwanza, and drive growth. He talks up linking rural areas to cities, credit lines for farmers, and Planagrão–a nationwide plan aimed at promoting the production of grains on a commercial scale.

- **Welcoming Foreign Investment**
  The Minister is enthusiastic about foreign investment, confidently dispelling concerns about potential red tape; he stresses that the reform agenda is anchored in "legal predictability, macroeconomic stability, and investor confidence."

The Minister has hailed the 2026 budget as a historic turning point where, for the first time, non-oil revenues are projected to structurally outweigh oil revenues.

MEETING WITH THEM

Massano is a relaxed and confident interlocutor, effortlessly delivering his key points in English or Portuguese to persuade his counterparts.

- **Making Connections**
  Massano looks for ways to affiliate with his counterparts. For example, he stresses shared experiences, noting that his family also struggles with high prices in local markets because “being in government doesn't insulate us from economic reality."

- **Providing Context**
  Massano often draws attention to Angola’s historical trajectory, gently trying to soften criticism. He counsels audiences to “remember, we had 27 years of civil war ending in 2002. In 20 years, we've built infrastructure; others took 50 years to develop. Our challenges are real but so is our progress."

Massano has been unapologetic about his reforms, especially the abolition of the fuel subsidy and its resulting street protests. In public remarks, he explained that "we planned gradual subsidy removal. Reality demanded faster action. We adapted. Rigidity in tactics while pursuing strategic goals is foolishness."

ON THEIR MIND

- **$1 billion debt facility with JPMorgan**
  Angola in January extended a one-year $1 billion debt facility with JPMorgan, opening a new tab for three years and secured an extra $500 million in financing. The new three-year contract carries an interest rate "within 8%", according to the Finance Ministry.

- **Interest Rate Cut**
  Angola’s central bank in January delivered its biggest interest-rate cut in nearly three years, reducing the rate to 17.5 from 18.5 percent. The Central Bank Governor said the move was “justified by the consistent slowdown in inflation.”

- **U.S. Support for Lobito Corridor**
  The U.S. International Development Finance Corporation in December signed a USD$553 million loan with a consortium of firms on Wednesday for the refurbishment of an Angolan railway line - part of the Lobito critical minerals corridor.

- **Pope to travel to Angola**
  The Vatican's ambassador to Angola announced that Pope Leo XIV will travel to Angola this year, calling it an opportunity “to rediscover the values that guide the Angolan people, and that those values can be shared with the diverse communities that live and work throughout the world."

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NETWORK

Massano is effectively managing the transition from President Joe Biden to Donald Trump, preserving major U.S. investments while remaining close to Chinese, Gulf Portuguese counterparts at the same time.

Massano, who had boasted that Angola and the United States were experiencing a new moment following Lourenço's meeting with Biden in 2024, has served as the point person to sign key agreements with the Trump Administration. At the same time, Massano has pushed for more Chinese investment, prioritized Gulf capital, and portrayed Portuguese companies as ideal partners.

Massano is one of Lourenço's most trusted advisors and he works seamlessly with Minister of Finance Vera Daves de Sousa and Transport Minister Ricardo Viegas D'Abreuas as part of Angola's dream team.

Massano has benefited from Lourenço's support three times: appointed BNA governor in 2017, reconfirmed in December 2022, and elevated to Minister of State in June 2023. As the face of Angola's reforms, Massano provides Lourenço with technocratic cover against any public backlash.

CONTROVERSIES

Massano has faced scrutiny over banking-sector governance and his personal wealth, though he has rejected allegations of impropriety.

- **BESA Bank Collapse**
  During his first term as BNA governor (2010-2015), Banco Espírito Santo Angola (BESA) collapsed amid allegations of accounting fraud and politically directed lending. Massano told parliament that BESA had "bad" and "irregular" credit operations but pushed back on suggestions of political favoritism.

- **Currency Museum Allegations**
  In January 2025, activist Rafael Marques de Morais filed a criminal complaint accusing Massano of embezzlement, influence peddling, money laundering, and tax fraud related to a Currency Museum project. Marques alleged that costs ballooned from $10 million to $64.5 million during Massano's BNA governorship. Massano responded that he was "absolutely calm" about the suspicion.

Reports have surfaced about a multi-million euro mansion in Quinta Patino, Cascais—one of Portugal's most exclusive areas. Critics argue such assets are inconsistent with a public servant's salary. His children are reportedly educated in elite European institutions.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of State for Economic Coordination**, Republic of Angola (2023 to present)
- **Governor**, Banco Nacional de Angola (BNA) (2017 to 2023; 2010-15)
- **Chairman**, Banco Angolano de Investimento (BAI) (2015-2017; 2006-2010)
- **Executive Director**, Banco de Poupança e Crédito (BPC) (1999-2006)
- **Accountant,** Sonangol (1997 to 2006)

BIO

Massano embodies Angola's new generation of technocrats – Western-educated, reform-minded, but deeply embedded in the country's political establishment. Born in Luanda circa 1970, Massano grew up during the country's civil war, eventually studying abroad with an eye toward helping his country prepare for post-war reconstruction.

- **UK Training**
  Massano holds a B.A. in Accounting and Finance from the University of Salford (1995) and an MSc from City University London (1996). His UK education shaped his preference for Anglo-Saxon market transparency; he frequently references "international standards" and "best practices."

- **Angolan Mission**
  When asked directly who he is, Massano has replied "a citizen who believes in Angola and who feels challenged every day to do more and better, to help the country grow—to help the country become better through his activities." He tells young people to "believe in Angola, and believe that together we are stronger—together we are capable."

Massano is married with children. He belongs to the Ambundu (Kimbundu-speaking) ethnic group, which has historically been the ethnic base of the ruling MPLA (Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola). He speaks Portuguese, English, Kimbundu, and is proficient in Spanish.

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